Handling Form Data

Christian Wenz
Consultant, Software Architect

@chwenz

HTTP Methods

GET	POST
Data appended to URL	Data in body of HTTP request
Size limit (~500-2000 characters)	No size limit, file uploads possible
PHP array $_GET	PHP array $_POST (and $_FILES for uploads)

Form Elements

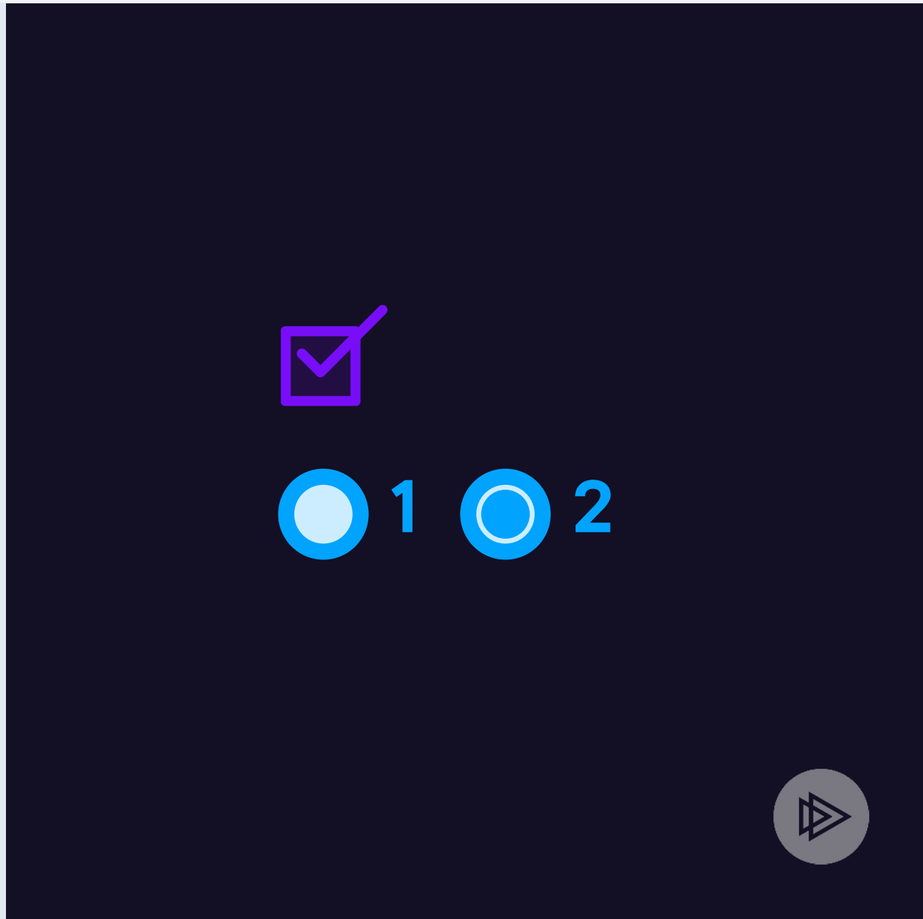
Text fields

```
<input type="text" name="txt">
<input type="password" name="pwd">
<textarea name="area"></textarea>
```

Form Elements

Radio buttons / checkboxes

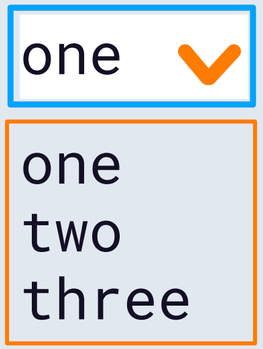
```
<input type="checkbox" name="chb" value="on">
<input type="radio" name="group" value="option1">1
<input type="radio" name="group" value="option2">2
```



Form Elements

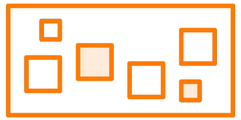
Selection lists

```
<select name="ddl">
    <option value="item1">one</option>
    <option value="item2">two</option>
    <option value="item3">three</option>
</select>
```

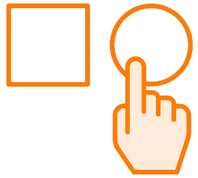


Processing Form Elements

Data is put into $_GET/$_POST arrays



Element’s name is array key



Value is content of text field, or button caption

Special Cases

Radio button/checkbox

```
<input type="checkbox" name="chb" value="on">
<input type="radio" name="group" value="option1">1
<input type="radio" name="group" value="option2">2
```

$_GET/$_POST contains value of selected button/checkbox

Special Cases

Selection list

```
<select name="ddl">
    <option value="item1">one</option>
    <option value="item2">two</option>
    <option value="item3">three</option>
</select>
```

one

$_GET/$_POST contains value of selected list element

Special Cases

Multi-select list

```
<select multiple name="list[]" size="3">
    <option value="item1">one</option>
    <option value="item2">two</option>
    <option value="item3">three</option>
</select>
```

one
two
three

$_GET['list']/$_POST['list’] contains array with values of all selected list elements

Escaping Form Output

User input is not trustworthy

- Might contain JavaScript -> Cross-site scripting (XSS)

Use htmlspecialchars() to escape special characters

- < > " ' &

Demo

Accessing form data

Validating Form Data

Check for non-empty values for text fields, radio buttons, and checkboxes

Special treatment for lists

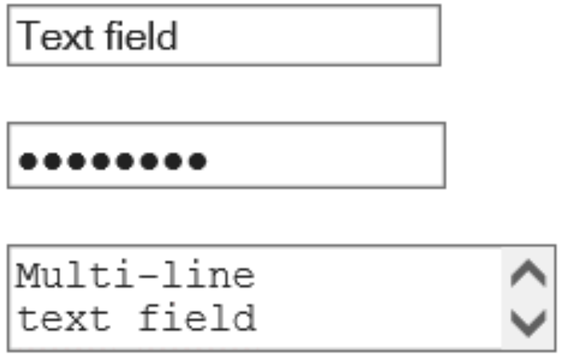
Consider using JavaScript or HTML validation as an additional feature

```php
$regex = '/^\w+@(\w+\.)+\w+$/'; //regular expression

if (!preg_match($regex, $_POST['key'])) {
  // input does not match regular expression
  echo 'Format error!';
}
```

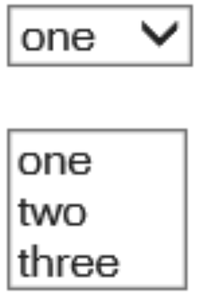
Form Validation with Regular Expressions

Prefilling Form Fields



Set value or content appropriately

Pre-activate item if applicable



Pre-select list item(s)